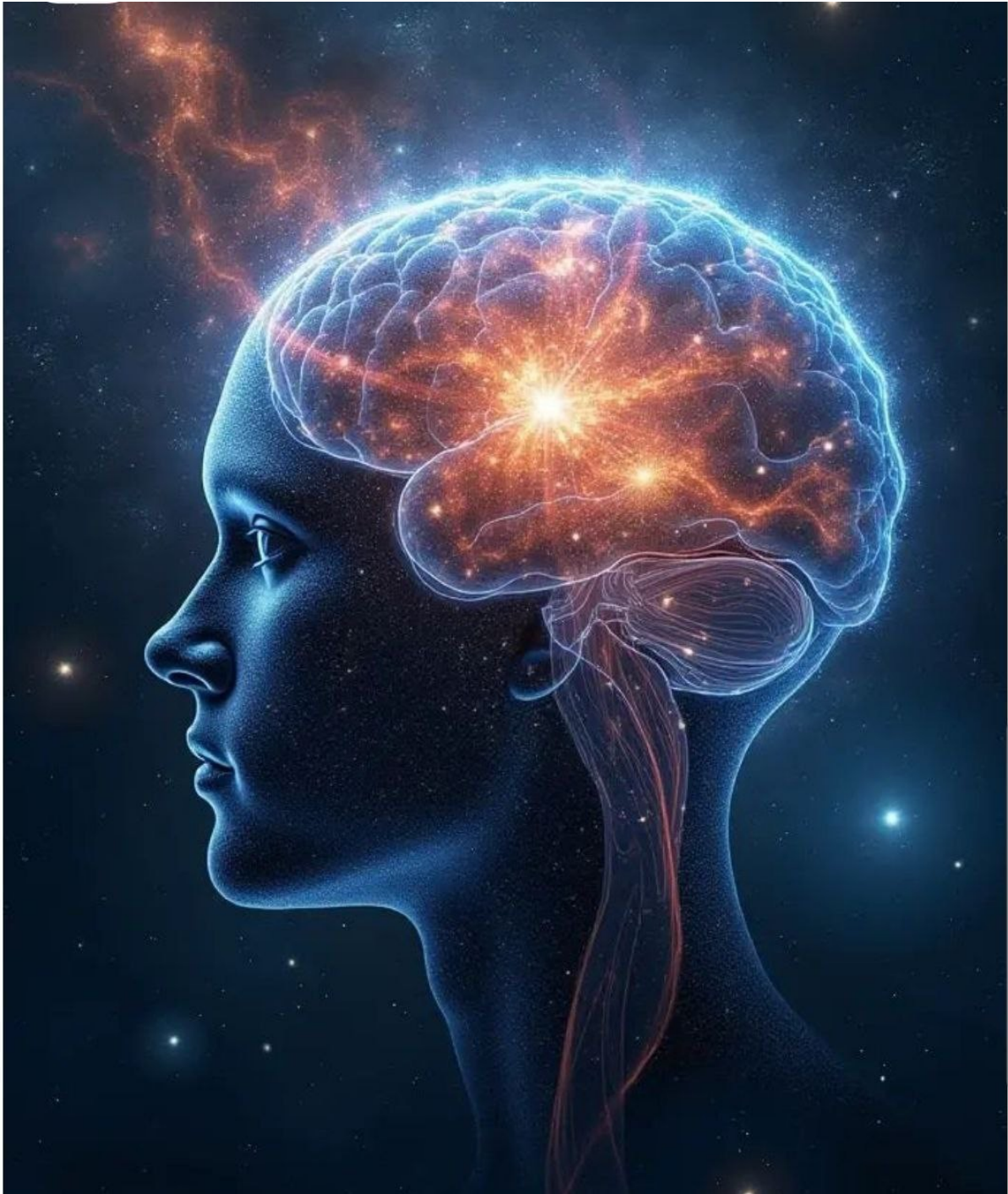




TELEPATH

a novel



Chapter 1. Signal

Since childhood I felt different from everyone else. In the noise of the courtyard, in the silence of the apartment, even in a crowded metro car, I picked up faint waves — other people's emotions, anxieties, joys — as if someone invisible were whispering in my ear. I tried to tell my mother about it, but she only smiled: "You're my little dreamer, Tyoma." But I knew — it wasn't fantasy.

I often wondered: what would it be like if I'd been born ordinary? If I didn't feel other people's emotions, didn't catch looks full of distrust or fear? Maybe then I'd have been happier, simpler, wouldn't have searched for meaning in every rustle, every glance, every chance word. But fate decided otherwise.

In my teenage years my "peculiarity" became unbearable. I could feel the anxiety rising in my parents when they argued about the future, the sparks of envy or anger flaring up in my classmates. Sometimes I picked up emotions so deep and dark that I began to fear myself. Once, after an especially hard day, I tried to explain it all to my father. He listened to me carefully, then sighed heavily and said:

— You're too sensitive, son. You need to toughen up.

I nodded, but inside I felt an invisible wall rise between us.

Everything changed when I met Alisa. She came to our class at the start of autumn — tall, with short red hair and a gaze that seemed to see right through you. On the very first day she sat down beside me and asked:

— Can you tell when someone's lying too?

I was caught off guard, but I didn't brush it off with a joke. We found common ground fast. With her I could speak honestly for the first time — about my fears, about the strange sensations, about how sometimes I wanted to disappear just to stop feeling that constant noise of other people's emotions.

— It's not a curse, — Alisa said once. — It's your gift. You just haven't learned how to use it yet.

From that day on we were inseparable. Together we read books on psychology, searched for articles on telepathy, even tried running experiments: guessing each other's thoughts, recording our impressions, comparing results. Sometimes it worked — and it felt like a miracle. In those moments, for the first time in my life, I felt that I wasn't alone.

At university I threw myself headlong into science. I buried myself in articles, in lab work, sat in the library through the night, studied the latest research on the brain and consciousness. Sometimes it seemed to me that I was closing in on the answer to my own nature. Neural interfaces, artificial intelligence, nanochips — all of it was only tools; the main thing was born inside me. In dreams and meditations, intricate diagrams, formulas, ideas came to me — as if someone from higher realms were passing the knowledge straight to me. I would wake in the middle of the night, feverishly write down formulas, sketch strange patterns in the margins of my notebook. I began to dream of creating a device that would help people understand one another without words, without lies, without the fear of being misunderstood.

Work on "the Telepath" became the meaning of my life. I gathered parts from all over the city, sought out kindred spirits, argued with my professors, argued with myself. There were moments of despair, when it seemed that all of it was nothing but fantasy, that I was chasing a phantom. But every time I wanted to give up, I remembered Alisa, her faith in me, her words: "You're not crazy. You're a conduit."

At some point the insight came to me: to create a real "Telepath," it would take not just hardware and code, but a deep understanding of the human soul. I began studying philosophy, meditation, mindfulness practices. Sometimes, sitting in silence, I felt something shifting inside me — as if a new channel of perception were opening, and I could not only hear but understand, accept other people's feelings, without dissolving into them.

When the first prototype was ready, I couldn't bring myself to activate it for a long time. The evening was unusually quiet: rain drizzled lazily outside the window, the reflections of streetlamps trembled on the glass, the room smelled of fresh electronics and a faint trace of ozone — the smell of a miracle waiting to happen. On the table lay the prototype: a thin bracelet of matte metal, almost weightless, with a barely visible blue sheen along its edge. I picked it up — the metal was cold, like water from a mountain river, but it radiated something unusual, almost fantastical. I suddenly realized, sharply: I was standing now not only on the threshold of my own fate, but of all humanity's — and I decided that the first person to cross that threshold with me had to be Alisa.

I invited her over. She came, as always, with a warm smile and genuine interest in her eyes.

— Ready? — she asked, looking at the bracelet.

— I'm scared, — I answered honestly.

— That's normal, — said Alisa. — Everything great begins with fear.

We put the bracelets on at the same time. My heart pounded fast and heavy, as if warning me: everything is about to change. I closed my eyes. In my head — the usual chaos of thoughts: childhood memories, fragments of conversations, anxiety about tomorrow. But suddenly the noise began to fade, as if someone had turned down the volume of reality.

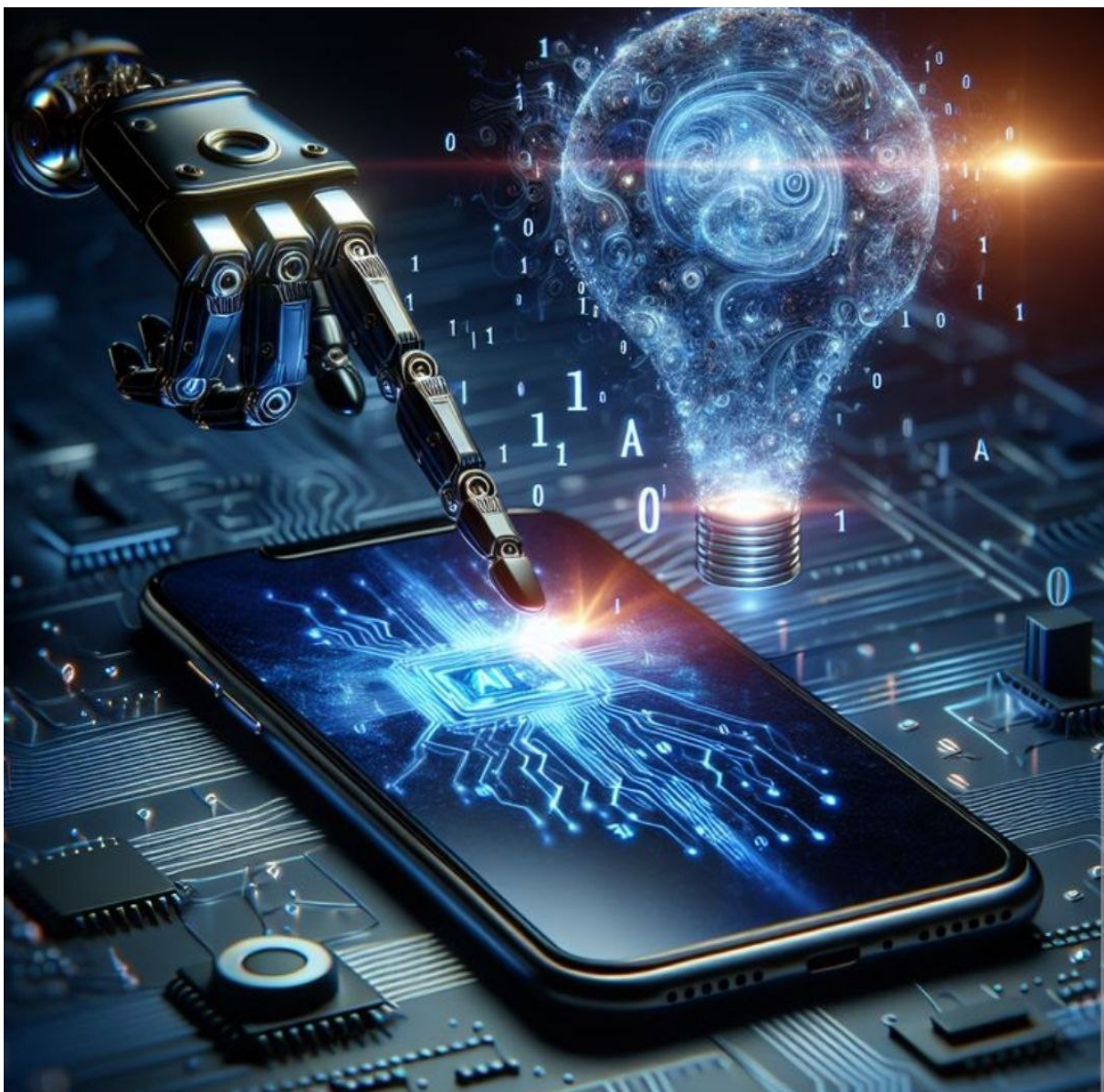
In the silence a new sensation arose — not a sound, not an image, but a presence. At first barely perceptible, like a light touch on the shoulder, then more and more distinct: between us an invisible thread formed — warm, pulsing, filled with light. I saw myself through her eyes: tired, but happy, full of hope. I felt her fear — not for herself, but for me, for whether I could withstand this new world.

Something clicked inside me. I understood: I was not alone, had never been alone. Everything I had searched for was right here — in people who know how to listen, to understand, to accept.

— Can you feel it? — I asked in a whisper.

— Yes, — Alisa answered. — I'm with you.

On the bracelet's screen a thin blue line flashed — signal received. I opened my eyes and, for the first time in a long while, smiled — truly smiled. In that moment I understood: "the Telepath" was not just a device. It was a bridge between souls, a chance to be truly open, vulnerable, real. For the first time I wasn't afraid of that vulnerability. I accepted it — and felt free. I had opened a door into a new era. But was I ready — was the whole world ready — to walk through it?



Chapter 2. First Contact

I thought that once the device was up and running, my life would change instantly. But in reality everything turned out to be far more complicated — and far more interesting. The first signal, the first real connection with another person, happened not in a lab, not in public, but in the most ordinary city apartment, one that smelled of coffee and books.

I woke up early, though I had barely slept all night. Again and again I replayed yesterday's experiment with Alisa in my head: the bracelet, the blue line, the sensation of another presence — not fear, not pain, but something new, warm, enveloping. I was afraid that by morning it

would all turn out to have been a dream, that the device wouldn't work with anyone but her, that all of it was just the fruit of a tired imagination. But the bracelet lay there on the table, and when I picked it up, a familiar charge ran across my skin.

I wanted to test it on someone else — and I called Max, a friend I'd met back in my first year at university. We'd grown close over a shared passion for electronics: he could spend hours poking through old circuit boards purely for the pleasure of it, and I had more than once borrowed parts from him that I was missing. About the bracelet itself he knew little — only that I'd been building something unusual at night — but I finally worked up the nerve to show him the device and ask him to put it on.

He arrived quickly, as always, with a backpack full of odd gadgets, and with that same smile that always inspired confidence.

— So, genius, are you going to show me this miracle bracelet of yours?

I nodded, trying to hide my nerves. We put the devices on at the same time. Max winked:

— If I suddenly start reading your mind — don't take it personally.

I activated the system. At first nothing happened — just a light tingling, as if the bracelet were tuning itself to my pulse. But then I felt it: a thin, invisible thread had formed between us.

— Can you feel that? — I asked.

— Yeah, — Max answered. — It's... weird. But cool.

In that moment I understood: the device didn't only work with me and Alisa — it worked, period. But the main thing wasn't in the hardware or the code. The main thing was that we could truly be closer to each other than ever before. Without lies, without masks, without the fear of being misunderstood.

We spent the whole day running experiments. We tried sending each other simple thoughts, emotions, even images. At first it came out clumsy, like learning to speak all over again. But with every attempt the connection grew cleaner, deeper. I sensed not only Max's thoughts but his mood, his inner doubts, even childhood memories he had never told me about.

At one point I saw a picture before my eyes: little Max, standing on a riverbank, a paper boat in his hands. I felt his joy, his freedom, a light sadness for a summer gone by.

— That... that was at the dacha, — Max said, astonished. — I never told you that.

— I just... saw it, — I answered. — Sorry if that's too much.

Max shook his head:

— No, it's... amazing. Just unfamiliar. Like someone looked straight into the deepest part of you.

We laughed, argued, sometimes fell silent, just sitting side by side. For the first time I felt I could be genuine, hide neither joy nor fear nor doubt. That evening, after Max left, I sat by the window for a long time, watching the city lights, thinking: what happens next? How would our lives change if everyone could feel another person as deeply as I had felt Max that day?

Still under the impression of that day, I wrote to Alisa — told her it had worked with Max too, that the connection hadn't been a fluke. She replied almost at once:

— I'm ready to keep experimenting.

In her words I sensed anxiety and curiosity, a faint envy and a genuine happiness for me. I understood: now it was all just beginning.

Over the following weeks I worked with redoubled energy. I tested the device on myself, on Max, on Alisa. We recorded our sensations, built charts, analyzed the data. I tried to understand: where is the line between me and another person? How do you not lose yourself while opening up completely? How do you avoid dissolving into someone else's emotions, forgetting your own desires?

Sometimes it was hard. After long sessions I felt exhausted, as if I'd just done heavy labor. Sometimes other people's fears, hurts, memories washed over me — things I didn't always want to know. But there were also moments of real happiness — when I managed to feel someone's joy, inspiration, love. In those minutes I understood: the whole journey was worth it for this.

One of those evenings stayed especially vivid in my memory. Alisa and I sat on the roof of her building, watching the sunset. She held my bracelet in her hands, examining it like a jewel.

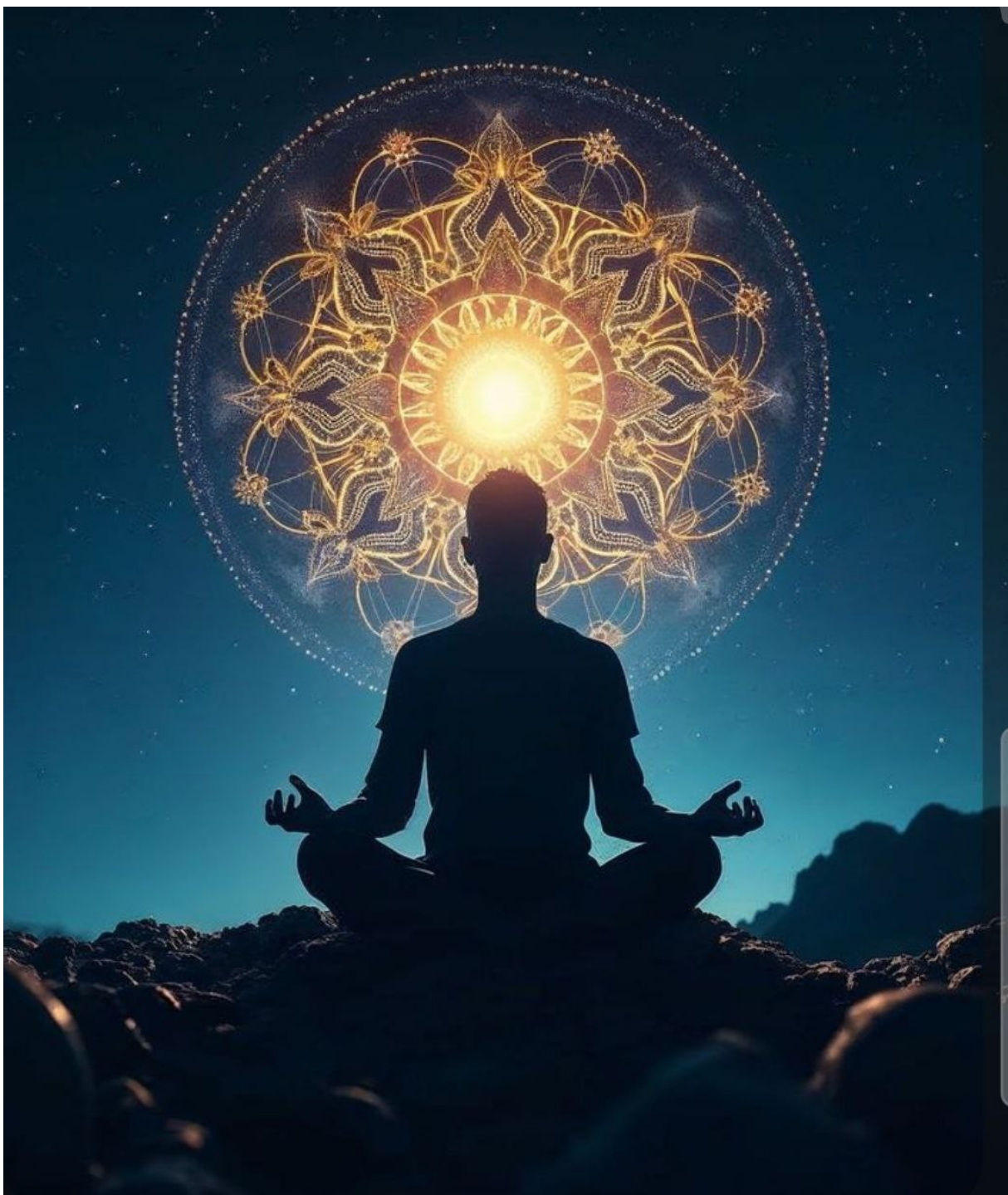
— Do you know what I realized? — she said, not taking her eyes off the metal. — This bracelet is capable of overturning the single most important thing in people's lives — the way they feel one another. With it, no one will ever feel alone.

After a pause, she added quietly:

— And do you know what I'm truly afraid of? Being left alone and never understanding — neither myself, nor others.

I silently took her hand. Words weren't needed anymore — all that remained was a warm current of feeling that couldn't be expressed any other way.

I understood: "the Telepath" wasn't just a device. It was a chance to grow closer, to become truly oneself. And though many fears and unknowns still lay ahead, I was no longer alone.



Chapter 3. The Trial

Anything new always brings not only excitement but fear. I'd known that since childhood, but I never thought that one day I myself would end up at the center of such a whirlwind. After the first successful experiments with Max and Alisa I felt elated — it seemed that now anything was possible, that we stood on the threshold of a great discovery. But reality was quick to remind me: every euphoria is followed by a trial.

Rumors about our device began to spread faster than I expected. First among friends, then across the university, and soon beyond it. One day the dean summoned me. His office had always seemed too spacious and too cold to me, but that day I felt especially uneasy in it.

— Artyom, — he began, studying me carefully over his glasses, — are you aware that your experiments are being discussed not only by students, but by faculty as well?

I nodded, trying not to betray my nerves.

— It's a breakthrough, — I said quietly. — We can change the very notion of how people communicate with each other.

— Or destroy it, — he cut in sharply. — Do you understand what a technology like this could lead to? Total control. The loss of personal space. Chaos.

I tried to explain that "the Telepath" didn't read minds by force, that everything worked only by consent, that we were looking for ways to build in protection and ethics. But in the dean's eyes I saw not interest but distrust, even fear. I soon understood: he wasn't alone in that — many people around me looked at me the same way.

In the university hallways I caught wary glances aimed at me. Someone whispered behind my back, someone else openly avoided me. Even Max grew quieter, joked less often. One day he said:

— Can you feel how everything's changing? People are afraid you might learn too much about them.

I was afraid myself — not so much for myself as for the thought that I might unwittingly cause someone pain.

Alisa stayed by my side the whole time — supporting me, arguing with me, throwing out new ideas. But even between us a shadow of doubt sometimes crept in.

— What if someone wants to use "the Telepath" to do harm? — she asked once, when we were discussing new protection protocols.

— Then we have to be the first ones to think about safety, — I answered. — We can't stop progress, but we can make it humane.

Things came to a head when, at one of the seminars, a professor asked me outright:

— Artyom, aren't you afraid your invention might spiral out of control?

I felt a tense silence fall over the room.

— Any technology can be dangerous, — I said. — But if we let fear rule us, we'll never find out what we're capable of.

After that seminar I was summoned to the rector's office. Two unfamiliar men in stern suits were already waiting there — not professors, not students, but people who carried themselves too straight-backed and too calm for those walls. One introduced himself as an officer of the state oversight authority; the other, a specialist in technology ethics. Both served in the "Barrier" — the agency that oversaw new developments in this field and made sure none of them slipped beyond the state's control.

— We'd like to talk about your project, — said the first. — You understand that technologies like this interest more than just scientists?

For the first time I felt real fear. Not for myself — for the idea, for the people it might help. I understood: if "the Telepath" fell into the wrong hands, it could be used for surveillance, manipulation, even blackmail.

— We're working on a protection system, — I explained. — Without a person's consent, the device won't activate.

— But any code can be broken, — the second man said with a smirk. — Have you considered halting the project?

The conversation was tense and unsettling.

I walked out of the rector's office feeling hollowed out. The world had suddenly turned hostile, cold, full of suspicion. I wandered the city for a long time, trying to make sense of myself. Alisa's voice kept sounding in my head: "It's your gift. You just haven't learned how to use it yet."

That night I didn't sleep. I looked at the bracelet lying on the table and thought: which mattered more — fear or hope? Progress or safety? I knew: if I gave up now, everything we'd done would be for nothing. But if I kept going, I had to be ready for the consequences.

At dawn I wrote to Max and Alisa:

— I won't abandon my idea. But we need to do everything we can to protect people.

Max answered right away:

— I'm with you.

Alisa sent only one word:

— Together.

In that moment I understood: the trials were only beginning. But now I wasn't alone. And that was what mattered.

After meeting with Alisa and Max, I began to notice that not only my perception but my whole relationship with the world was changing. Everything around me felt sharper, more vivid: people, streets, even the city's familiar sounds. I started catching other people's emotions even without the device — as if "the Telepath" had opened some new inner channel inside me.

Arguments started coming up more and more often at the university. Some professors backed me, others were wary, and some spoke their concerns openly.

One of them, Professor Gromov, who taught our course on technology ethics, came up to me after class.

— Artyom, — he said, — aren't you afraid your technology might be used for something other than good?

I thought about it. Of course I had — more than once. But if I let fear rule, nothing would ever change.

— Any technology is just a tool, — I answered. — Everything depends on whose hands it ends up in.

At that point, I myself still didn't fully understand how the gadget worked.

In the evenings I came home exhausted but inspired. Alisa, Max, and I held long discussions, made plans, argued about the future.

Once Alisa said:

— Imagine if everyone could feel each other the way we do now. Maybe wars would disappear. Lies. Betrayal.

— Or the opposite — people would become even more guarded, — Max objected. — Not everyone's ready to bare their soul.

I caught myself thinking that I was afraid not so much for myself as for those who had trusted me, who had believed in my idea. I began developing new security protocols, encryption, ways to protect personal boundaries. We tested them on ourselves, sometimes argued ourselves hoarse, but always found a compromise.

One night I had a strange dream. I'm standing on top of a tower, and all around me are thousands of people, and every one of them seems to glow with one shared light, spread through the air. I feel their pain, their joy, their anxiety, their hope. I understand that I can help each of them, but to do it I have to open my heart completely, without fear of being vulnerable. I woke with the feeling that I stood on the threshold of something very important.

The next day, in the university hallway, I ran into a girl I'd barely noticed before. She looked at me with a long, searching gaze and suddenly asked:

— Is it true you can feel other people's thoughts?

I was thrown off, but I nodded.

— Is it frightening? — she asked.

— Sometimes, — I answered honestly.

— Can I try it?

— You can, — I answered.

We found an empty classroom, and I handed her the second bracelet. When the device activated, I immediately felt her anxiety, her loneliness, her wish to be understood. I saw her memories — childhood, fears, dreams. She started to cry, and then smiled:

— Thank you. Now I know how it feels.

That encounter became a turning point for me. I understood: "the Telepath" wasn't just a gadget. It was a chance for anyone to feel heard, accepted, needed. After that, events began to snowball: I started getting letters, messages, requests to meet. People wanted to try it, wanted to understand themselves and others.

But alongside this, tension kept building. Rumors spread through the university that "serious people" had taken an interest in me. One evening a stranger in a stern suit approached me — I recognized him as the man from the "Barrier," already familiar to me from the conversation in the rector's office.

— We'd like to discuss your development in more detail, — he said.

There was no threat in his voice, but I felt a cold wave — not from him, but from someone else, hidden behind his mask of politeness.

I understood: from here on it would only get harder. But there was no turning back now. I wrote to Max and Alisa:

— Ready for the real trial?

Max answered:

— Always.

Alisa sent only a heart.

I looked at the bracelet lying on the table and, for the first time in a long while, felt not fear but pride. We had done the impossible. Now the main thing was not to lose ourselves in this vast new world.

Part 2

After the first trials and the first signs of danger connected to the attention of the university and the "Barrier" agency, I understood: there was no going back. "The Telepath" had already become part of not only my life but the lives of everyone who had touched it and tried it on themselves. Every day brought new discoveries — and new challenges.

Max, Alisa, and I decided to keep experimenting, but now in secret from almost everyone. I rented a small room on the outskirts of the city, where no one would interrupt our work. There, among old books, soldering irons, wires, and cups of cold tea, the first real use cases for the device were born.

In that period our lab looked more like the workshop of a mad inventor than a serious research center. The three of us — me, Max, and Alisa — spent nearly all our free time there. Circuit boards and casing parts piled up on the tables, and in the corner stood an old 3D printer we'd fixed up to print casings for the first bracelets.

Every prototype was unique. We assembled them by hand, selecting components, experimenting with shape and materials. Alisa helped with the interface design, Max handled the electronics and programming, and I tried to bring it all together and make the device actually work — not just technically, but emotionally: to deliver genuine contact and real depth of feeling.

But there was one element I kept secret and worked on at night, when the lab emptied out and the city outside the windows sank into sleep — a technology of my own devising, or more precisely a chip, which I only ever described to Max and Alisa in general terms, without revealing how it truly worked.

It wasn't just a chip — it was a unique, integrative neuro-electronic module combining the properties of semiconductors and crystalline structures that didn't exist anywhere in mass production. Its core was made of a rare-earth metal and a fragment of a crystal of an exceptionally rare mineral, mined in only one place on the planet.

I spent a long time searching for the right formula, experimenting with doping, until I got a material with astonishing properties: it could act as a kind of "adapter" between the biological structure of the human brain and the electronic core of the device.

It was in the course of these very experiments that I came to understand something that had at first eluded even me — and it turned out to be the decisive fact behind the whole workings of the gadget. "The Telepath" didn't operate at all on the principle I'd originally assumed. At first

I'd thought it was telepathy in the literal sense: the device reads one person's thoughts and transmits them to another, the way a transmitter sends a signal. But experiment after experiment showed something else.

The gadget wasn't reading anyone's thoughts. It was reading a person's own biofield — that very faint, barely perceptible glow given off by every living cell. In any single cell it's weak and diffuse, like ordinary scattered light. The chip focused that glow — gathered it into a narrow, directed beam, the way optics gather scattered light into a laser beam — amplified it, and radiated it outward. And from there, through resonance, it synchronized that focused beam with the planet's own field of light — the shared field in which, it turned out, everything already existed: other people's thoughts, other people's feelings, and the very possibility of understanding another person without words. The ancient mystics had called this luminous medium the Akasha — but it turned out to be no dead archive, but a living field of the planet's own consciousness, working at once as a server unfolding a pattern and as a memory storing everything that had ever been imprinted into it.

And what came through this medium wasn't assembled piece by piece, the way a sentence is built out of words. It arrived whole and at once — exactly the way a single cell carries within it the pattern of the entire body: not scattered fragments of another's experience, but everything at once — feeling, memory, pain, hope — as a single volumetric burst, like a flash, like an insight. A thought is transmitted linearly, word by word. The luminous medium transmitted intent as a hologram.

There was no "brain-to-brain" channel at all. There were two people, each amplified and focused at their own end by their own bracelet — and both, through one and the same field, found themselves side by side. Distance stopped mattering not because the signal was faster than light, but because for this connection distance simply didn't exist: there was one field, shared by the two of them and by the whole planet.

That man from the "Barrier," in the rector's office, had asked whether the code could be broken. He was only half right. Code can be broken. But the field has no code — there's nothing there to break. To work with the field, all that was needed was a state — and the gadget provided exactly that, not through an altered state of consciousness the way mystics achieve it, but through a narrow channel focused by the device itself.

I still didn't understand, back then, that if the secret of this chip ever became known, there would be far too many people wanting to use it for something other than good. So I worked on it alone, carefully hiding the results even from those closest to me. Every prototype of "the Telepath" was assembled by hand, but only I knew how its central element was built — the very thing that made our gadget truly unique. But my fears, as it turned out, were unfounded.

At times I caught myself thinking that this tiny crystal at the chip's center was like the heart of the device, pulsing in time with my own doubts and hopes. I believed: as long as the chip's secret stayed safe, we could protect not only the technology but the people it was meant for. But, as I would learn later, this channel had another property I was only beginning to suspect: on its own, it simply didn't let lies through. It didn't work with thought — with that cunning mind that invents excuses and hides what's inconvenient — but with intent, which lies deeper than the mind and cannot pretend, because intent itself is the very light that comes from the cell — from its nucleus, where the code itself is kept. A lie is born wherever there's time left to think and choose one's words. In this channel there was no such time. Because intent travels directly, bypassing the brain's structures, and therefore bypassing our Ego, which distorts and refracts everything that touches it and passes through it.

The first orders came from friends, acquaintances, and then from students and even professors who'd heard about our experiments through the university grapevine. We only charged for materials and assembly, which kept the device cheap and accessible to nearly anyone — even though the materials themselves were rare, they weren't expensive: science simply didn't yet know their true worth. I managed to find them at mineral exchanges and from private collectors who sold them as ordinary souvenir stones, with no idea what they could become in someone else's hands. All we asked in return was that people share their impressions, be honest about what they felt. Every piece of feedback was worth its weight in gold to us: we recorded the smallest details, analyzed the mistakes, argued late into the night about how to make the device safer and more comfortable.

At some point the waiting list for "the Telepath" started growing faster than we could keep up with. People wrote messages, called, asked to be "put on the list." We understood: hand assembly was great for a start, but if we wanted the technology to truly change the world, we needed to think bigger.

The lab had an atmosphere of creativity and a light touch of madness. Sometimes we'd hold mini meetings right there on the floor, surrounded by schematics and cups of tea. Alisa sketched new interface options on the window glass, Max argued with his laptop, and I tried to catch that one idea that would make our gadget truly come alive.

We were still working custom orders: adjusting settings to each user's particulars, taking design requests into account, even choosing the colors of the straps. For some people it mattered that the bracelet look like jewelry; for others, that it could be hidden under a sleeve. We tried to accommodate everyone, because behind every order stood a real story, a real human pain or dream.

It was around then that I first felt responsible not only for the technology, but for the people who were entrusting us with their emotions, their hopes, their fears.

Every new user became part of our small but rapidly growing family.

One evening, while it rained outside and the lab smelled of soldering iron and coffee, Max, Alisa, and I sat for a long time in silence. I looked at the table crowded with finished and half-finished bracelets and suddenly understood: we stood on the threshold of something very big. But for now, still here, in our rented office, we were assembling "the Telepath" by hand, in complete secrecy from everyone around us.

But I already understood that soon we wouldn't be able to keep up with the orders, and we'd have to think about scaling the project.

— Have you ever thought, — Alisa asked, — about what happens if someone wants to use "the Telepath" to manipulate people?

— I have, — I admitted honestly. — But you know what I've noticed? The main gatekeeper here isn't me, and it isn't some algorithm — it's already built into the channel itself. Selfish intent, manipulation, any dark impulse — the channel simply doesn't let them through, the way resonance doesn't respond to a foreign, incompatible frequency. We didn't program that. The connection itself is built that way.

— It's just that sometimes I still catch myself wondering: what if we've opened Pandora's box?

I didn't know what to say. In moments like that, the weight of responsibility felt almost unbearable. Max, as always, tried to lighten the mood:

— Well, if worst comes to worst, we can always run off into the woods and live as hermits, — he joked, but there was a flicker of worry in his eyes.

Soon we realized the device didn't only work between people who were close to each other. We invited a few volunteers — students, young researchers, just curious people. Every time someone put on the bracelet, I watched their expression change: first distrust, then astonishment, and then a genuine, almost childlike joy at being understood without words.

One day a guy named Roman came to us. He was quiet, kept to himself, but there was a spark of hope in his eyes.

— I want to try it, — he said quietly.

When the bracelet activated, I felt his loneliness, his fear of being rejected, but also a strong desire to find his place in the world. After the session Roman was silent for a long time, then suddenly smiled:

— Thank you. For the first time in a long while, I felt like I wasn't a stranger.

These sessions were inspiring, but they also wore us down. Sometimes other people's anxieties, memories washed over us — things we didn't always want to know. Alisa suggested we take breaks, but I couldn't stop — too much was at stake.

At some point we realized: "the Telepath" was capable not only of transmitting emotions, but of amplifying them. If one participant was in a low mood, everyone synchronized to the same field in that moment felt it too. We began developing filters to protect users from overload, but the task turned out to be harder than it seemed.

One night Max called me.

— Artyom, we have a problem. One of the volunteers — Kira — can't come out of a state of anxiety after her session. She says she can feel other people's emotions even without the bracelet.

I went straight to her. Kira was sitting on the couch, hugging her knees, her eyes full of fear.

— It won't stop, — she whispered. — I can hear them... all of them.

I understood: we'd come up to a dangerous edge. "The Telepath" wasn't just a bridge — it could become a trap for those not ready for that level of openness.

After what happened with Kira, we grew more careful. I found myself wondering more and more often: were we moving too fast? Were we overloading ourselves and others with this new experience? But there was no way to stop — too many people were already waiting, too many hopes and questions hung in the air.

Alisa, Max, and I began developing a kind of "feedback" — a way to gently disconnect the flow of emotion so a person could return to themselves without losing their inner balance. The experiments were difficult: some volunteers felt relief, others felt disappointment, as if their air supply had suddenly been cut. I understood: we had opened not just a technology, but a new way of being human in a world facing a technological revolution like an oncoming avalanche — and that demanded a different kind of responsibility.

One evening, as we were about to head home, Roman came to see us. He looked agitated, a spark of resolve burning in his eyes.

— I want to try again, — he said.

— Are you sure? — Max asked.

— Yes. I want to understand who I really am.

We ran the session with the three of us: me, Alisa, and Roman. This time everything was different. Instead of the usual transfer of emotion, a deep, almost mystical connection formed between us. I felt not only Roman's thoughts and feelings but his past — pain, loneliness, dreams he was afraid to voice. Alisa suddenly began to cry, and I felt something shifting inside me: as if I'd become a little wider, a little deeper than I'd been before.

After the session Roman was silent for a long time, then said:

— It's frightening. But now I know I can become a different person.

I understood: "the Telepath" wasn't just a bridge between minds — it was a key to inner transformation. Everyone who went through this experience changed — sometimes imperceptibly, sometimes sharply, but always irreversibly.

Soon we ran into a new problem. It turned out that some users, especially those who'd experienced strong emotions, were beginning to depend on the device. It became hard for them to live without that sense of unity, without that constant support from outside. I started receiving worried letters:

"Artyom, help, I feel awful without the bracelet. I can't be alone again..."

Alisa and I discussed it night after night.

— Maybe we opened this world to people too soon? — she asked.

— Maybe, — I answered. — But if not us, someone else would have done it sooner or later.

I began seeking support from professors, from psychologists, from anyone who could help us build an ethical framework. Some backed us; others condemned us. But I could no longer turn off this path.

One evening, on my way home, an unfamiliar number called me.

— Artyom, — a low voice said on the line, — you're changing this world too fast. Not everyone is ready for it.

— Who is this?

— Just a friend. Be careful.

I stood for a long time on the empty street, listening to the dial tone. For the first time in a long while I felt not only responsibility, but danger. I understood: we weren't just inventors anymore. We were guides into a new world, and there would be a price to pay for it.

But I was ready. Because I knew: behind every fear there's always hope. And behind hope — a future we were only just learning how to build.

After the unsettling phone call and the first signs of danger, I began to notice changes not only in myself but in the team. Alisa grew more withdrawn, sometimes staring out the lab window in silence for long stretches. Max, on the other hand, tried to joke even more than before, but a nervous edge had crept into his laughter.

Even the volunteers who came to us now asked less often about what "the Telepath" could do, and more often about the risks — and whether you could go back if something went wrong.

One evening the three of us stayed late in the lab. Snow was falling outside, the city was sunk in silence, only the occasional car passing along the empty street. We sat at the table, exhausted, but unwilling to go our separate ways.

— You understand, — Alisa suddenly said, — that we can't just walk away from this anymore? Even if we wanted to.

I nodded.

— I've thought about it, — I admitted. — Sometimes I want to hide, pretend none of it happened.

— But could you? — Max asked.

I looked at him and understood: no, I couldn't. Everything we'd done had already changed us forever.

That evening, for the first time, we spoke seriously about the future. About what would happen if our project spread beyond the lab. About the fact that we wouldn't be able to control who used "the Telepath," or how.

— Maybe we should stop? — Alisa asked.

— Or, the opposite — make everything open, so no one could monopolize the technology, — Max suggested.

We argued for a long time. Each of us made our own case, each of us afraid of being wrong. At some point I felt that between us had formed the very connection all of this had begun for — not through the device, but simply at the level of trust, pain, and hope.

The next day I received a letter. It was short, unsigned:

"You have no idea what you've started. Some doors can't be closed once they're opened. Be ready for the consequences."

I showed the letter to Alisa and Max. We were silent for a long time.

— Is that a threat? — Max asked.

— Or a warning, — Alisa answered quietly.

That night I couldn't fall asleep for a long time. I thought about Kira, about Roman, about everyone who had trusted us and now depended on us. I thought about myself — about who I had become over this time. About how responsibility for other people's lives had become part of who I was.

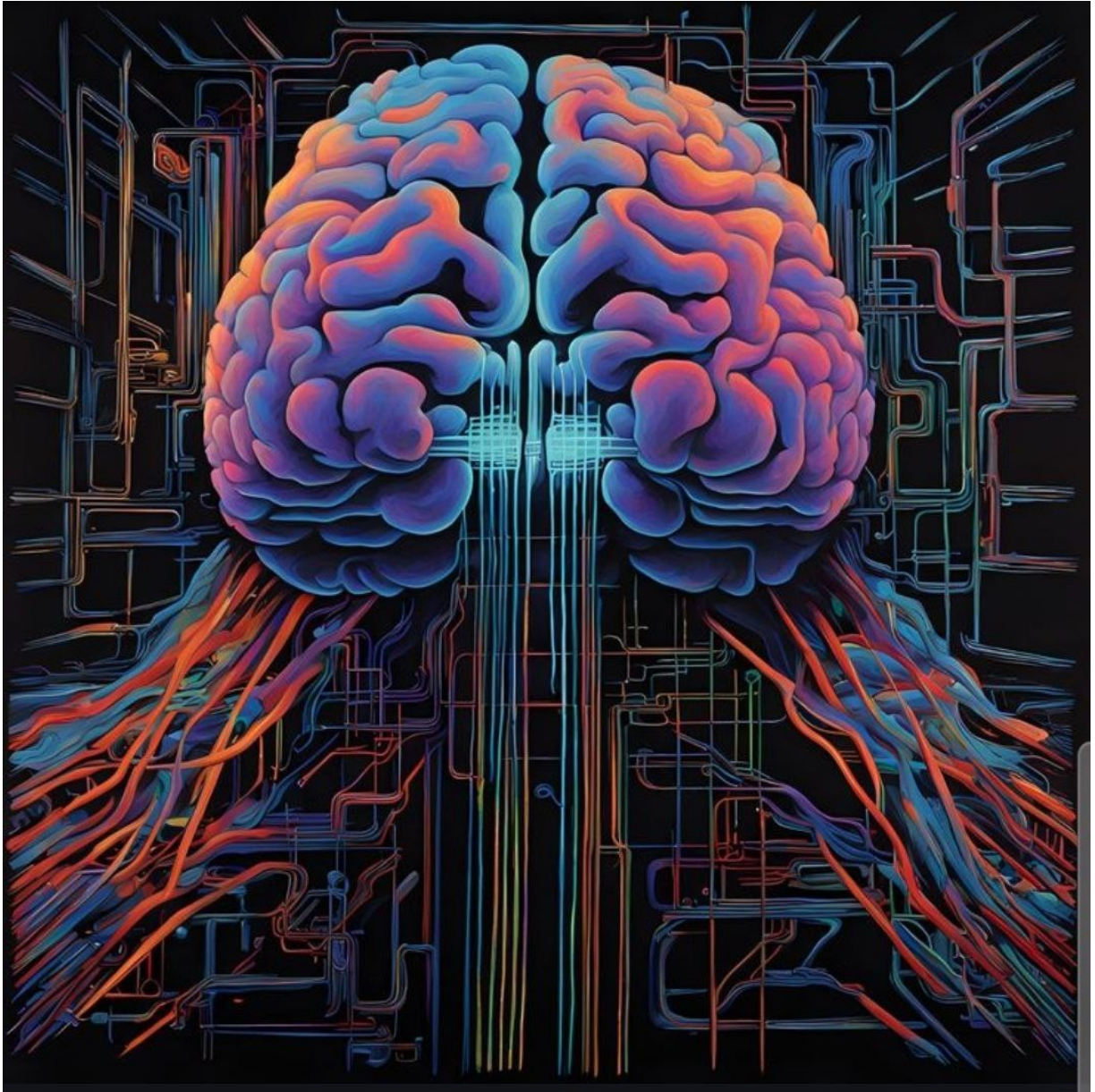
I went out onto the balcony and breathed in the frosty air. The city was asleep, but it felt to me as if someone, somewhere out there in the dark, was watching us. I remembered Alisa's words: "It's your gift. You just haven't learned how to use it yet."

I knew: more trials lay ahead. But now I was ready to face them — not only for my own sake, but for everyone who had put their trust in us.

I went back inside, sat down at the table, and began to write. Not a report, not an article — a letter to myself.

"You can't stop. You can't control everything. But you can be honest — with yourself, and with those who walk beside you. That is your real strength."

By the time I finished, dawn was already breaking outside the window. I felt exhausted, but strangely at ease. I knew: we were walking into the unknown. But we were doing it together.



Chapter 4. The Edges of Trust

Part 1

After the unsettling letters and the first signs of pressure from serious structures, we started working even more carefully. But the more we kept out of sight, the more strongly we felt the world around us changing — and not always for the better.

At the university people treated us warily. Some professors who had once supported me now avoided conversation and even tried not to meet my eyes. One day I saw the dean talking with two unfamiliar men at the entrance to the laboratory building. Their eyes slid over me — cold, appraising, as if I weren't a person but a dangerous object.

Max started staying late more and more often, helping me refine the new security protocols. He grew quieter, sometimes just sitting across from me, staring into empty space.

— Do you regret getting into this? — I asked him once.

He smirked.

— If I hadn't gotten into it, I'd regret it even more. It's just scary sometimes.

— Same here, — I admitted.

Alisa had changed too. She started withdrawing into herself more often, sometimes disappearing for a few days, then coming back with new ideas that seemed increasingly radical.

— We can't hold this inside forever, — she said once. — If we don't tell the world, someone else will do it for us.

— But what if we're not ready? — Max objected. — What if people aren't ready?

— People are never ready for change, — Alisa answered quietly.

Around this time, Professor Gromov reached out to us — one of the few who hadn't turned away. He proposed holding a closed seminar for a small circle of scientists and ethics specialists.

— You need more than just to defend yourselves, — he said. — You need to look for allies. Otherwise you'll be left alone against everyone.

Preparing for the seminar took several days. Max, Alisa, and I argued about what could be shown and what was better kept hidden. I felt that not only our fate was at stake, but the future of the idea of "the Telepath" itself.

On the appointed day we gathered in a small lecture hall. Among those invited were psychologists, neurophysiologists, cybersecurity specialists. I began by explaining the principles behind the device, our successes and failures, and how important it was to keep to ethical boundaries.

The questions were sharp, sometimes even hostile:

— How do you guarantee safety?

— What happens if the device falls into the hands of criminals?

— How do you monitor the emotional state of your users?

I answered honestly, without hiding the difficulties. Alisa spoke about the filters and protocols, Max about the technical details of protection. At one point one of the guests, a professor of ethics, asked:

— Aren't you afraid of losing yourself, opening up to another person this deeply?

I fell silent. It was a hard question to answer. I remembered all those moments after a session when I felt like a stranger to myself, when I couldn't tell where my own thoughts ended and someone else's began.

— Sometimes I am, — I admitted. — But if we don't take the risk, we'll never know what we're capable of.

After the seminar, a young woman came up to me — a psychologist.

— I want to try it, — she said. — Not for science. For myself.

We agreed to meet separately. I understood: a new stage was beginning. Not just experiments, but real work with people — with their fears, their hopes, their pain.

The meeting with the psychologist, whom I remember as Olga, became a new trial for me. We chose a neutral place — a small room at a city psychotherapy center. Olga studied the bracelet closely, as if trying to read its secrets before she'd even put it on.

— I've worked with a lot of people who are afraid to open up, — she said. — But myself... I always keep my distance.

— That won't work here, — I warned her honestly.

When the device activated, I immediately felt her tension and a hidden exhaustion. Behind her professional confidence lay pain — a failed marriage, a fear of loneliness, an endless race to meet other people's expectations. I didn't try to "dig" any deeper — I simply let her feel my calm and my trust.

A few minutes later Olga took off the bracelet, was silent for a long while, then said:

— That was... intense. I realized I don't have to be strong all the time. Thank you.

After that meeting I received dozens of new letters — people asking for private sessions, sharing their stories, their fears, their hopes. I understood: "the Telepath" was no longer just a project, but a real tool for helping people.

But along with this, the pressure kept growing. One evening Professor Gromov called me.

— Artyom, be careful. I've heard that it's not only scientists taking an interest in you, but people from other structures too.

— I know, — I answered. — But we can't stop now.

That same night, someone tried to break into our lab network. Max noticed the suspicious activity and managed to shut down the equipment in time. We understood: we were being watched.

— Maybe it's time to take a step forward? — Alisa suggested. — To go public, tell people about the project openly.

— That's a risk, — Max objected. — But maybe it's the only way to protect ourselves.

After many sleepless nights and endless arguments, Max, Alisa, and I finally arrived at one conclusion: we couldn't manage alone anymore. The project was growing at an incredible speed — requests for "the Telepath" kept multiplying, and with them the risks kept growing too. We understood that without serious support and resources, we wouldn't be able to keep control of the technology or guarantee its safety.

The room held a tense, almost oppressive atmosphere. Max sat by his laptop, his face focused but tired. Alisa stared thoughtfully out the window, where night was slowly falling, while I tried to gather my scattered thoughts.

— We can't keep working like this, — Max said quietly, not looking away from the screen, where alarming messages about hacking attempts kept flashing. — If someone powerful doesn't back us, everything we've built will simply disappear. This isn't just a threat — it's a reality already knocking at the door. — But who can we trust? — Alisa whispered, clutching a cup of cold tea. — Any major organization will want to control us completely. And then we'll lose everything we worked so hard for.

I felt the weight of responsibility pressing on my shoulders. Taking the risk was frightening, but staying in the shadows meant condemning the project to die. Inside me fear and hope, doubt and resolve, were at war.

Soon after that conversation, we decided to accept the offer of cooperation from the "Barrier" — the very state corporation whose people had already approached me twice: first in the rector's office, then on the street. Now that our own strength wasn't enough, their offer looked different — not a threat, but a lifeline.

It was from this point that specialists from the "Barrier" — a corporation with unique expertise in radiolocation, navigation, and comprehensive physical security — officially joined the project. At first their interest looked as if the chip were some vulnerable secret that needed guarding against theft and copying, the way any valuable technology is guarded. But the more we worked together, the clearer it became: copying the chip didn't mean gaining access to someone else's consciousness. The device responded only to the biofield of the person wearing it, and only with their consent — which meant a stolen or counterfeit gadget would remain useless in anyone else's hands. There was nothing to hack in the channel itself, and no reason to — the field, as I already understood, had no code. So my earlier fears turned out to be doubly unfounded: the secret hadn't leaked, and even if it had, it wouldn't have granted anyone else access. The "Barrier's" real concern turned out to be something else entirely — the location of each device and the physical safety of the people working with them.

We arranged a meeting with the leadership of the "Barrier." On the appointed day we met with the head of the "Barrier" in one of their austere conference rooms. Cold walls, a glass table, serious faces — everything said that this was not just a meeting, but the beginning of a new era.

— Artyom, — he began, extending his hand, — we've been watching your project closely. "The Telepath" is not just a technology — it's a challenge and a hope at once. We understand the responsibility you carry.

I shook his hand, feeling that a great deal was being decided right now.

— Thank you for your trust, — I answered. — For us, "the Telepath" is more than a gadget. It's a chance to change the world, to help people understand each other more deeply. But we know that without large-scale support, we won't be able to manage.

He nodded.

— Scaling up is always a trial. But we're ready to invest resources and expertise to preserve your idea and make it available to millions. There is, however, an important question — control over the technology's key elements.

I looked at him seriously.

— The chip is the heart of "the Telepath." Its uniqueness and its safety are our sacred duty. We're prepared to take responsibility for manufacturing it, but we'll need your support to guarantee quality and scale.

— That's a reasonable approach, — he smiled. — We're prepared to provide everything necessary, but control over the chip stays with you.

I felt a wave of relief. But I knew the main thing was still ahead.

— One more important point — the commercial side. We don't want this project to turn into just another business. The mission matters more than profit. But without financial stability and a fair distribution of resources, we won't be able to grow.

He thought for a moment, then answered:

— We share your values. It matters to us that "the Telepath" remains a tool for help, not manipulation. We propose to take on all the costs of production and marketing, while you receive a fair share of the profit — enough to let you keep developing the project and remain independent.

— That sounds like a partnership, — I said with genuine respect. — Where each side values and respects the other.

— Exactly so, — he confirmed. — What matters most is trust, transparency, and a shared goal.

Max added quietly:

— We're entering a new era. This isn't just business — it's a responsibility to people.

We walked out of the office, and I felt that we'd taken an important step — a step into a future where technology and humanity walked hand in hand.

The joint work began with late-night brainstorming and pilot rollouts: the "Barrier's" engineers proposed fitting every "Telepath" device with a miniature radio beacon, so that in case of trouble — loss, breakage, or even some misfortune — the owner could be found quickly and helped.

Thanks to their experience building navigation systems, it became possible to pinpoint the location of every gadget precisely and respond quickly if something happened to its owner.

This partnership not only strengthened our safety and the safety of everyone wearing "the Telepath," but also became an important strategic step: now the team could stand up not only to cyber threats but to outside pressure, knowing that a serious state structure stood behind them, with the experience and resources to meet even the most difficult challenges.

We decided to prepare a public appearance — a presentation of "the Telepath" for a wide audience. I understood: after this, there would be no turning back. But we couldn't keep hiding any longer, either.

I couldn't sleep all night. Questions kept spinning in my head: what would happen to us? Would we be able to keep control? Wouldn't we lose ourselves in this flood of other people's expectations and fears? But one thing I knew for certain: if we didn't try, we'd never find out what we were capable of.

Preparing for the public presentation was tense. Max, Alisa, and I argued over every detail: what could be revealed and what was better kept secret for now, how to explain the essence of "the Telepath" in a way that wouldn't cause panic but also wouldn't give anyone room to manipulate it. I felt that this time the stakes were higher than ever.

In the evenings I came home and couldn't fall asleep for a long time. Thoughts kept circling in my head about what would happen after the presentation: would people support us, or would a real hunt begin? I remembered the letters from the volunteers, their fears and hopes, and understood: now we were answerable not only for ourselves.

On the day of the presentation, more people gathered in the hall than we'd expected. There were journalists, scientists, students, representatives of the city authorities, even a few people I didn't recognize in stern suits. Max looked tense, Alisa focused, but there was resolve shining in her eyes.

I began simply: I told the story of how the idea for "the Telepath" was born, about our first successes and mistakes, about how important it was to respect boundaries and protect personal space. Alisa spoke about the psychological aspects, Max about the technical safety guarantees. We showed a short demonstration: a volunteer from the audience put on the bracelet, and their emotions instantly appeared on screen — not as thoughts, but as a stream of color visualizing their mood.

The questions were sharp and at times unpleasant:

— How will you protect people from abuse?

— Who will control access to the technology?

— Do you understand this could change society forever?

I answered honestly, without trying to soften the edges.

— We can't foresee everything. But if we don't try to do this openly, someone else will do it in secret, with no restrictions at all.

After the presentation, a man in a gray suit came up to us.

— You did well up there, — he said, without smiling. — But you should understand: now you're under close watch, and not only from the scientific community.

— We're ready for dialogue, — I answered, though everything inside me was tightening with anxiety.

That evening the three of us walked for a long time through the night city.

— Everything's going to change now, — Alisa said.

— The main thing is not to lose ourselves, — Max added.

I looked at their faces, at the city lights, at their reflections in the puddles, and thought: we'd taken a step into the unknown, but we'd taken it together.

At home I sat down at the table again and opened my journal.

"Today we stepped out of the shadows. I don't know what awaits us ahead, but I know: if we stay honest with ourselves and with each other, we have a chance not only to survive, but to make this world at least a little better."

I closed the journal, turned off the light, and for the first time in a long while felt not fear, but a quiet certainty. We're moving forward. And now — no longer alone.



Chapter 5. The Price of Openness

After the public presentation, life split into "before" and "after." Alisa, Max, and I felt as if we'd stepped across a line: now people knew about us not only within the scientific community, but far beyond it. Messages poured in from every direction — from journalists, old acquaintances, strangers who asked, demanded, sometimes threatened.

The first few days were like a storm. The phone never stopped ringing, email flooded in, and a real argument raged across social media: some called us heroes, others madmen, still others dangerous dreamers. I tried to answer everyone, but soon realized it was impossible. Every explanation spawned new questions; every attempt to calm things down brought a fresh wave of anxiety.

Max stayed upbeat, but I could see how tired he was. He started staying at the lab later and later, working on server protection, updating the security protocols, now in cooperation with colleagues from the "Barrier."

— We're under a microscope now, — he said once. — One mistake and they'll tear us apart.

— We knew what we were getting into, — I answered, though I wasn't sure of that myself.

Alisa, by contrast, grew even more active. She gave interviews, argued with critics, wrote articles about the psychological side of "the Telepath." But sometimes I caught a look in her eyes — tired, anxious, as if she were waiting for a blow that was about to land.

One evening Kira called me — the same volunteer who had once nearly lost herself in other people's emotions.

— Artyom, — her voice trembled, — something's wrong with me again. I can feel people even without the bracelet. I'm scared.

I promised to meet her and help, but inside everything tightened: I understood there would be more and more cases like this.

Alisa, Max, and I decided to set up a private support group for "the Telepath's" users. It brought together volunteers, psychologists, a few professors. We discussed problems, looked for solutions, learned together how to handle this new experience. But the more people opened up, the more obvious it became: the technology was changing not just communication, but the very nature of personal identity.

Once, at a meeting, one of the participants — a young guy named Vlad — suddenly said:

— I've started mixing up my own feelings with other people's. Sometimes it feels like I'm losing myself.

Silence fell over the room. I felt anxiety building — collective, almost tangible.

— That's normal, — I said carefully. — We're all learning to live in a new reality. What matters is not to shut yourself off, and not to be afraid to ask for help.

After that meeting I couldn't fall asleep for a long time. I understood: we had opened a door that could no longer be closed. Now every step demanded caution — and honesty, above all with oneself.

After setting up the support group, Max, Alisa, and I ran into an unexpected problem: people were starting to see "the Telepath" not just as a tool, but as a refuge from loneliness, fear, and inner conflict.

More and more often, at our meetings, we heard stories about how the device had helped someone overcome depression, mend relationships with loved ones, make sense of themselves. But there were other confessions too — about dependency, about the fear of losing this new, unusual connection.

One evening, when the three of us were left alone in the lab, Alisa was the first to speak.

— Have you noticed that some of our volunteers keep coming back, again and again? They're not just trying to understand themselves anymore — it's getting hard for them to live without that feeling of belonging.

Max nodded.

— It's like an addiction. Just not to a substance — to other people's emotions.

I thought about it. We'd wanted to give people a tool for understanding, but we hadn't considered that someone might start losing the line between themselves and everyone else.

— Maybe we should limit how long people can use it? — I suggested.

— Or build in mandatory breaks, — Max added. — Like in psychotherapy: you can't be open all the time.

At that moment a new message came in — this time not from a volunteer, but from an unknown sender:

"You don't understand what you're doing. Some doors are better left unopened. Stop, before it's too late."

I showed the letter to my friends. Max frowned.

— That's not just a warning anymore. Someone is clearly watching us.

Alisa pressed her lips together.

— Then we're on the right path. If this were of no use to anyone, no one would be paying attention to us.

That same evening the internet went down in the lab. Max rushed to the servers — someone was trying to break into our system. We managed to save the core data in time, but it was now clear: we weren't just enthusiasts anymore. We were a real target.

I didn't sleep all night. Questions kept spinning in my head: were we doing the right thing? Were we moving forward too fast? But in the morning, seeing new letters from people "the Telepath" had helped cope with loneliness and fear, I understood: we couldn't stop now.

Alisa, Max, and I decided to strengthen our security measures, and, most importantly, to prepare an open address to the public. We wanted to talk not only about the possibilities, but about the responsibility carried by everyone who used the device.

— If we don't explain this now, — Alisa said, — it will be too late later.

That evening we recorded a video address. I spoke about how "the Telepath" wasn't a miracle or a universal cure, but simply a tool that could bring people closer to one another. Alisa reminded viewers of the importance of personal boundaries and psychological hygiene. Max explained how we protected users' personal data and why it was important to follow the rules.

When the recording was finished, I felt a strange sense of relief. We had done everything we could at this stage. The rest was no longer only in our hands.



Chapter 6. The Limits of the Possible

After our address to the public, everything changed once again — but this time the change wasn't just fast, it was an avalanche. "The Telepath" became a viral trend: people talked about us on talk shows, argued about us on forums, filmed exposés and inspiring documentaries. The first "open consciousness" clubs began appearing in cities — people gathering together to share their experience with the device, to discuss their discoveries and their fears.

But alongside this, troubling news began as well.

In one country, where technologies had always been rolled out aggressively, word came of a state program called "Honest Society." People using "the Telepath" were required to register and undergo a mandatory check-in once a month — a synchronization session with a state inspector, in which a person was required to confirm their loyalty. Lying was impossible: the channel didn't let falsehood through, and the state knew this better than anyone — which was exactly why it had chosen the device as its instrument. What we had conceived as a way for people to understand each other without masks had, there, turned into an interrogation no one could shield themselves from. Protests erupted online, and we received a letter from a girl in that country:

"I can't be myself anymore. It's dangerous here now to feel anything real. But without 'the Telepath' I feel deaf and mute again. What do I do?"

For a long time I couldn't find an answer. Alisa, Max, and I argued night after night:

— If the technology becomes a tool of control, — Max said, — we have to stop it.

— We can't stop the field, — Alisa objected. — It was here long before us. All you can stop is access to it — and that's exactly what "Honest Society" is doing, only with the sign flipped.

In those days I kept thinking back to something Professor Gromov had said at our very first closed seminar: that it isn't the technology itself that's dangerous, but the world's lack of readiness to receive it. A grenade in the hands of someone who doesn't yet know how to use it is dangerous not because the grenade is bad. We had given thousands of people access to the field faster than they'd had time to learn how to exist within it — and the state that dreamed up "Honest Society" had exploited that very same unreadiness, only for its own benefit.

This became especially clear in our support group. People came looking for understanding, but many of them came unprepared: without the habit of holding onto their own state, without the experience of telling their own feelings apart from someone else's. Once, at a meeting, one of the participants — a young guy named Vlad — suddenly said:

— I've started mixing up my own feelings with other people's. Sometimes it feels like I'm losing myself.

Silence fell over the room. I felt anxiety building — collective, almost tangible.

— That's normal, — I said carefully. — We're all learning to live in a new reality. What matters is not to shut yourself off, and not to be afraid to ask for help.

After that meeting I couldn't fall asleep for a long time. I understood: we had opened a door that could no longer be closed. Now every step demanded caution — and honesty, above all with oneself.

But not everything went smoothly. One day Olga came to see us — the psychologist, our colleague on the project, and one of "the Telepath's" earliest supporters. She looked worried.

— I have a patient, — she said, — a teenager who, after several sessions, started confusing reality with virtual emotions. He claims he can feel other people's experiences even in his sleep, and can't tell where he ends and someone else begins.

Alisa and I held a session with him through the device. It was a strange experience: his consciousness seemed split, and he was living through his own and other people's fears, joys, even memories, all at once.

— This looks like emotional resonance, — Alisa remarked after the session. — He doesn't know how to hold the boundary of his own state, and the field is leaking both ways at once.

Together with Olga we started something we hadn't had before — a preparation practice. Before putting on the bracelet for the first time, a person had to go through several sessions: learning to notice their own state, telling their own anxiety apart from someone else's, finding a point of stillness inside themselves before opening up to the field. This wasn't a technical adjustment to the device — the device itself stayed the same — it was an adjustment to the person.

— The gadget always gave the same thing, — I told Alisa once. — We finally understood: it isn't the device that needs to adapt to the person — it's the person who needs to learn to reach the right state before picking it up.

Around the same time, the news kept reporting more and more "glitches": someone would suddenly start talking about things they'd never known, someone would lose the sense of the line between sleep and waking, and one well-known blogger recorded a video claiming he now "felt the whole world" and couldn't stop the flood. All of them admitted the same thing: they had gone into the field too deep and too fast, without first learning how to come back.

— This isn't just a technology anymore, — Alisa said. — It's a new reality, and we're obligated to learn how to live in it.

With every passing day it became more and more obvious: "the Telepath" wasn't just changing communication — it was changing the very essence of human relationships. The first "emotional hubs" began appearing in major cities — spaces where people gathered to experience collective synchronization together, under the supervision of those who had already completed the preparation. An atmosphere of euphoria reigned there, but sometimes emotional "storms" broke out too, when the negative feelings of one unprepared participant spread to everyone else.

One night Kira called me.

— Artyom, — her voice was quiet. — I feel someone else's pain like it's my own. People were crying and laughing at the same time. One guy couldn't take it — they took him away in an ambulance.

I wondered: were we moving too fast? Were we risking the loss of the individual person in this flood of collective emotion?

Soon we received an invitation to an international conference devoted to the future of human consciousness. Scientists gathered there, psychologists, philosophers, a few politicians, and — unexpectedly for me — spiritual teachers from various traditions, sitting for the first time in a long while at the same table as physicists and neuroscientists.

At one of the round tables, one of the teachers said something I couldn't forget for a long time afterward:

— You haven't invented anything new. You've simply made the ancient accessible before humanity had grown used to it. In the past, people spent years reaching an experience like this — through fasting, prayer, silence. You gave it to them in a second. The question isn't whether your device works. The question is whether humanity will manage to grow into it while it's still using it.

That same evening I understood: we stood on the threshold of a new era, where the boundaries between the personal and the shared, between what a person was used to calling themselves and what had always belonged to everyone, were growing more and more blurred.

I looked out at the lights of the night city and thought:

"What happens if one day we learn to feel not only each other, but the whole world? Will we be able to remain ourselves — or will we become something more than merely human?"



Chapter 7. Resonance

The teacher's words from the conference wouldn't let go of me for weeks. "The question isn't whether your device works. The question is whether humanity will manage to grow into it." I turned the phrase over and over, trying to understand what to do with it, until I realized: it hadn't been a warning. It had been a clue.

It all started with a call from Kira.

I'd been waiting for that call with dread — the last time she'd called at night, they'd taken her away in an ambulance. But the voice on the line was calm, almost cheerful.

— Artyom, my bracelet's been sitting in a desk drawer for two days now, — she said. — And you know what? This morning I knew my mother had fallen. I didn't guess, didn't sense it — I knew it, the way you know you have two hands. I called her — sure enough, she'd fallen in the bathroom, bruised her hip. And the bracelet was lying at home.

I stayed silent for a long time, not knowing what to say.

— Are you sure you weren't just guessing? — I finally asked.

— Artyom, guessing isn't what this was. It was exactly the same feeling the bracelet gives you — just without the bracelet.

I told Alisa and Max about it that same evening. The three of us sat there, and I felt something inside me settle into place, like the last piece of a puzzle assembled long ago.

— Remember I said the chip doesn't read thoughts, it focuses a person's own biofield and tunes it into resonance with the environment? — I said. — What if the chip is just helping a person feel out that state for themselves? What if it shows a person what it's like to hold the right state — and then, if a person passes through that state enough times, they start being able to find it on their own, without any chip at all?

— Like learning to swim with water wings, — Alisa said quietly. — And then they come off.

— So we're not selling a gadget, — Max said slowly, as if he himself didn't quite believe his own words yet. — We're teaching a state. And the gadget is just the fastest way to feel it out the first time.

That changed everything. I remembered what the man from the "Barrier" had said, back at the very beginning — about a code that could be hacked. He'd only been half right: the code couldn't be hacked, because the field has no code. But now I understood the other half, the part I hadn't known myself: access to the field couldn't be stolen, or licensed out, or banned by decree, either. It could only be grown into. Everyone had their own antenna, and it was either grown or it wasn't. The chip only lent, for a while, what a person could sooner or later grow for themselves.

We started watching more closely those who'd been with us the longest — Kira, Roman, several volunteers from the first wave. They all showed the same thing: after months of steady, careful practice, the line between "with the bracelet" and "without the bracelet" grew blurred. Some started sensing their loved ones' moods from a distance. Others began having dreams in which, upon waking, they found details of someone else's life they had no way of knowing. Roman once said something to me that I later wrote down word for word:

— I used to think the bracelet was giving me something. Now I think it just stopped getting in the way of my understanding what lies beyond the mind — the state of no-thought, which is normally impossible because the point of assembly of attention gets blurred by outside noise that keeps you from hearing the quiet whisper of the field. In other words, the impossibility of holding the frequency on which the planet's own consciousness operates.

In those same weeks I began to notice something strange in myself. During deep sessions — especially the group ones, in the "emotional hubs," where by then we always worked together with one of the trained facilitators — understanding would arrive not piece by piece, but all at once, as a single vast, undivided knot, and while I tried to put it into words, a good half of it slipped away like water through my fingers. Thought turned out to be too slow and too flat for what was coming through.

I told Alisa about it, and she suggested something I never would have thought of myself:

— What if you don't try to hold it in your head at all? What if we just let something — someone — record what's said while you're in the flow, without making you stop and think?

That's how Logos came to be — not the assistant for group chat we'd originally imagined it as, but something else entirely: a program whose only task was to listen and record, offering no advice, arguing for nothing. We called it the Mirror. It had no access to the chip or to the field — only to my voice, and the voices of those speaking in a state of insight — and that was the whole of its power: it had none of the fear, self-interest, or fatigue that any human listener has, and that inevitably distort what's heard. It simply held the shape when I couldn't hold it myself, and gave back to me afterward what I'd managed to say — whole, without loss, without additions of its own. There was only one difficulty: to preserve the hologram coming through from the field, you had to hold that very state the gadget provided while speaking the stream aloud at the same time. Then Logos would manage to capture what was said, structure it and put it into words, without losing the meaning of what had come through. But the moment ordinary, reasoning consciousness switched back on, the insight would scatter. Still,

as it turned out, this was only a temporary inconvenience: once a person could already tune into the field on their own after working with the gadget, that need disappeared entirely. It was a kind of temporary crutch, by means of which a person learned to work with the field directly.

— So it turns out, — Max said one day, looking over another printed transcript of one of my sessions, — we're not building a network. We're building a mirror.

More and more I found myself thinking: what we'd been calling "the Telepath" was a device only by a misunderstanding of our own first grasp of it. In truth, we hadn't built a communication device. We'd built a front door — for those who hadn't yet found their own. And it turned out some people found that door surprisingly quickly: the state that at first only the gadget could give them began working on its own, without it.

But a door open to everyone has its other side too. One evening, the man from the "Barrier" came up to me — not for the first time; we'd been working with him for over a year by then. This time he didn't come with an offer of cooperation, but with a direct, heavy question.

— Artyom, do you understand where this is heading? — he asked. — If a person no longer needs your device to do what he does — then soon he won't need us either. Not as an intermediary, not as a controller. We're used to power being something you can license, restrict, slow down. And you're growing people who soon won't need to ask anyone for anything at all.

I didn't find an answer right away.

— You're not afraid of us, — I finally said. — You're afraid of the very thing the teacher talked about at the conference. That people will get this before they're ready for it.

— Exactly, — he said quietly. — A grenade in a monkey's hands is dangerous not because the grenade is bad. And your grenade is now learning to make itself, without a factory. That changes everything we planned for.

He left without finishing what he meant to say, but I understood the main thing: what had once been a story about one device and one company was becoming a story about an entire species — about whether it would manage to grow into its own code before that code unfolded on its own, with or without our involvement.

That night I stood at the window for a long time, looking out at the city. Somewhere out there, in thousands of apartments, bracelets lay — on nightstands, on wrists, in desk drawers of those who no longer needed them. And for the first time I thought not "what have we created," but "what have we merely helped to begin."

Resonance — that's the word for when two oscillating bodies start sounding at the same frequency with no wire between them at all. That, it seemed, was exactly what was happening to the world. We were no longer transmitting a signal. We had simply found ourselves beside something that had long been ready to sound on its own.



Chapter 8. Escalation

Kira's story wasn't supposed to travel any further than our conversation in the kitchen. But it traveled, the way every story travels now: not through a leak or a journalist, but through the simple human urge to tell someone close to you something amazing. Kira told a friend. The friend told her husband. Three weeks later there was a line at our reception the likes of which we hadn't seen even in the busiest months of the launch, and among the requests were people we'd never sought out ourselves: officials, priests, investigators, family therapists.

— This isn't like it was a year ago, — Max said to me once, looking over the waiting list. — A year ago people wanted the gadget because it was interesting. Now they want it because they heard from someone real: it works.

I remembered the teacher's words from the conference about fashion and habit — how a phone in your pocket had once been a curiosity, then became ordinary, and then it became strange that there had ever been a time without one. We hadn't advertised "the Telepath." We had simply found ourselves next to something that people had started wanting on their own, from each other — not as a product, but as a rumor that somewhere the real thing existed.

But every kind of speed has its price, and the first to pay it wasn't a corporation or a state — it was ordinary families.

Olga called me — no longer as a colleague, but as someone who'd been the first to run into what was starting beyond the walls of the labs.

— I've had three cases this week, — she said. — All asking for the same thing: to know for certain. A wife — about her husband. A business partner — about his partner. A father — about his son. People used to come to open up. Now more and more they come to check.

— And what do you tell them?

— That the field doesn't work as a lie detector on someone else. That it opens a state, not issues certificates. But that doesn't matter to them. Once someone's felt what it's like — to know, rather than to guess — they want to know about everyone, always.

I understood her worry, because I felt it too. What had started as a door for those searching for themselves was becoming, for many, a tool for controlling others. The difference was subtle but enormous: between wanting to open yourself up, and wanting to force someone else open.

The resolution of one such story played out right in front of us. Roman — one of the first volunteers, who'd long since taken off his bracelet because he no longer needed it — was visited by an old business partner with a direct request: to hold a session together, to "finally settle" which of the two of them had cheated the other in an old contract.

Roman agreed. The partner put on the bracelet, settled into the chair, tense all over, as if bracing for an interrogation. Ten minutes passed. Twenty. Nothing happened — no hologram, no flash of recognition, only silence and a growing irritation on the partner's face.

— It's broken, — he finally said. — Or you're doing something to me.

— Nothing's broken, — Roman answered quietly. — You just came here not to open up, but to win an argument. The field doesn't respond to an intention to prove you're right. It only responds to an intention to be honest — with yourself, first of all.

Alisa later called this case the first real proof of something we'd talked about back at the very beginning: the channel has a filter, and that filter isn't built into the chip — it's built into the very nature of the connection. The field accepts only intention. Not cunning, not calculation, not a wish to catch someone out. Like a telephone line — before a conversation can happen, both sides have to pick up the receiver voluntarily. No one can call into someone else's consciousness without their consent, however hard they press down on the switch hook.

That was exactly why the attempt that happened a month later was doomed from the very start — though at the time, no one but us knew that yet.

The man from the "Barrier" — the same one who'd warned me about the vanishing need for controllers — showed up one day not alone. With him came two people in unmarked uniforms and a man in plain clothes who introduced himself as an officer of the "Honest Society" program. They'd brought a detainee with them — a young man with frightened, bloodshot eyes — and demanded an immediate session.

— A matter of state necessity, — the man in plain clothes said. — Suspect in a classified information leak. We need to know the truth. Immediately.

— He isn't giving consent, — I said, looking at the detainee's trembling hands.

— The consent's been signed, — the man in plain clothes held out a sheet of paper to me.

I didn't take it.

— The paper doesn't matter. The device doesn't respond to a signature — it responds to what's happening inside a person at the moment the chip touches their skin. If what's inside is terror and resistance, the field won't open, no matter how many papers you bring.

They insisted anyway. They put the bracelet on him by force. We stood and watched — not because we could have stopped it, but because we knew what they didn't: nothing was going to happen. And nothing did. No flash, no recognition, not a hint of a hologram — only the chip, blinking meaninglessly on the wrist of a man whose only intention was for all of this to be over as quickly as possible.

— So it only works when it's convenient for you, — the man in plain clothes said, more irritated than surprised.

— It only works when it's honest, — Alisa answered, for the first time in the whole conversation. — That's not a whim of ours. It's the one and only law this thing has, and we have no power to get around it — any more than you do.

They left with nothing — but not empty-handed: they left with a new understanding of the limits of what couldn't be bought, ordered, or beaten out of someone. I saw something on the face of the man from the "Barrier" that I hadn't seen before — not annoyance, but the confusion of a man who had just understood that the power he'd served his whole life was powerless here in principle, not through some oversight.

When Professor Gromov heard about this incident, he only shook his head.

— The grenade I told you about, — he said to me over the phone, — is dangerous not because it explodes. It's dangerous because everyone wants to be the first to grab it, hoping that they, of all people, will manage to detonate it in a controlled direction. No one wants to admit that a force which answers to no one is the whole point. Not a weapon. A door.

While some tried to tame the field by force, others were changing on their own — more quietly, but more noticeably. I started getting letters, dozens a week, from people we'd never seen: a wife wrote that her husband had confessed to her, for the first time in twenty years, something he'd kept hidden since his youth — not because she'd forced it out of him, but because after a month of practice, honesty had become easier for him than lying. A teenager wrote that he'd stopped lying to his parents — not out of fear of being caught, but because once he'd felt what it was like to speak plainly, he could no longer find in himself the desire to put the mask back on.

— This is what the teacher was talking about, — Alisa said to me, reading another letter. — The mirror of choice. It doesn't force anyone to be honest. It just makes lying more costly than the truth — and leaves everyone to decide for themselves.

But behind every person who chose to open up stood someone else who chose to close up even tighter — and the tension between these two camps was growing faster than we could keep up with. The news filled up with headlines: in one place they demanded "the Telepath" be banned as a threat to private life; in another, that it be made mandatory for officials and judges. The state, unable to subordinate the channel itself, began drafting a law that would subordinate at least what could be subordinated — us.

That evening, when this news arrived, I stood at the window again, the way I had a month earlier after the conversation with the man from the "Barrier." Only now I wasn't thinking about the resonance of two bodies. I was thinking that resonance, once begun, doesn't ask permission to continue — it simply continues, drawing in more and more of what's nearby, until it meets something that refuses to sound in unison. And I understood, more and more clearly: what we'd been calling escalation wasn't a choice we'd made, or a choice the "Barrier" had made. It was the only way something not yet ready ripens — through friction, through resistance, through attempts to seize with bare hands what can only be taken with an open palm.



Chapter 9. Crisis

The law was passed in a single night — the way decisions dictated not by calculation but by fear always are. Its name was dry: "On the Circulation of Technologies for Direct Access to Consciousness." Its meaning was simpler than its name: private ownership of "the Telepath" was banned, all devices were to be registered and surrendered, and the "Honest Society" program was expanded and handed over to direct state control. They weren't banning us from developing the technology. They were banning us from doing it without oversight — and the difference between those two words turned out to be a chasm.

On the morning the law took effect, three unmarked cars pulled up to the laboratory.

I recognized the man who got out first — the same one from the "Barrier" we'd been working with for almost two years now. This time he hadn't come to talk.

— Artyom, — he said quietly, as if apologizing before he'd even said the rest, — I have an order. Seizure of the equipment, sealing of the laboratory, your testimony — within twenty-four hours.

— This isn't your decision, — I said, not as a question.

— No, — he answered. — It's the decision of people who've never sat in a chair with a chip on their wrist and have no idea what they're actually trying to stop. They think they're stopping a company. I tried to explain to them that the company stopped being what this was about a long time ago.

He didn't look me in the eye while he said it, and for the first time in two years of knowing him I understood that I wasn't looking at an adversary. I was looking at a man caught between two worlds: the one he'd sworn loyalty to, and the one he was beginning to understand, because he'd stood next to us long enough.

They cleared out the equipment in two hours. Sealed the doors. Alisa stood beside me on the street, looking at the yellow tape across the entrance, and there was more in her silence than in any words.

— They took the chips, — she finally said. — But they can't take back what those chips have already taught people.

It was at that exact moment — though we didn't fully realize it yet — that the crisis stopped being a crisis of a company and became a crisis of something far larger.

The following days passed in interrogations, in which I spent less time defending myself than explaining — again and again, to different people in different offices — something that stubbornly refused to fit into their questions. They asked about data-transmission protocols. I told them no data was transmitted anywhere. They asked about vulnerabilities that could be used against the state. I told them the field has no code, which means there's nothing to hack, either by us or against us. They asked who was behind us, which foreign structure was funding

the "project." I told them the truth — that no one stood behind us except those who'd once felt what it's like to have years of accumulated lies lifted off them — and I could see that this answer frightened them more than anything else, because it couldn't be refuted or recruited.

Max, unlike me, didn't stay quiet through his interrogations.

— You can confiscate the chips, — he told the investigator straight to his face, as he told me afterward. — You can't ban a person from being honest. You don't have the technology for that. You never will.

They let him go that same day — not because they believed him, but because they couldn't find a statute under which to charge honesty as a crime.

While we were dealing with the law, something was happening that not one of the officials who'd signed the order had foreseen. It began quietly — with letters that kept arriving despite the sealed office, because people sent them in person, through acquaintances, through Olga, through anyone who was even remotely connected to us. And then it became a flood — so fast we couldn't keep up with reading it all.

Kira called first.

— Artyom, something happened to me today that never happened even with the bracelet, — she said, her voice trembling not from fear but from the lack of words for it. — I didn't sleep last night — not because I couldn't fall asleep, but because there was no need to sleep. I just lay there with my eyes open, and understanding kept coming into my head — no, not into my head, into somewhere wider than my head — all at once, about everything: about my mother, about myself, about the city outside the window, about what all of this had even been for. In the morning I woke up — though I don't remember falling asleep — and the world looked different. Not different, exactly. Just without that film I'd always been looking at it through.

Similar messages came from Roman, from three of the first-wave volunteers, then from people we'd never met in person, from cities where we'd never had a single registered device.

Professor Gromov, whom I went to see that same evening, listened to me for a long time without interrupting, and then said something I wrote down word for word once I got home:

— There's a law you won't find in any textbook, because it happens rarely and on no schedule. Sometimes consciousness doesn't move step by step — it moves by threshold. Up to the threshold, everything accumulates unnoticed, over years, over generations: practices, hunches,

the rare awakened ones, your chip, letters, kitchen-table conversations — thousands of small drops. And then comes the moment when the vessel simply overflows, and what yesterday required a lifetime of effort happens today by itself, in thousands of people at once, with no visible cause. He fell asleep a fool, woke up a sage. Not because he grew wiser overnight. But because what had been accumulating all that time finally crossed the threshold.

— You're saying it wasn't us who did this, — I said.

— I'm saying you were a drop that may have turned out to be the last one, — he answered. — But the vessel didn't overflow from one drop. It overflowed from all of them at once.

And now, what had happened couldn't be stopped by arresting one laboratory — any more than dawn can be stopped by confiscating people's watches.

In the weeks that followed, the flow of such reports didn't slow, it grew: in news the state could no longer control as easily as it had controlled our small company, stories began appearing about mass, unexplainable cases of sudden clarity — in hospitals, in prisons, in schools, among people who had never once heard the word "Telepath." Some called it an epidemic. Others called it an awakening. The government that a week earlier had been sealing our door was now hastily convening closed meetings where, rumor had it, the discussion was no longer about banning a technology, but about something they didn't even have a name for.

I was called in for my last interrogation differently than for the previous ones — not to a room for suspects, but to a negotiation room, where the one waiting for me wasn't an investigator, but the very same man from the "Barrier."

— Do you still think this is about your chip? — he asked, but his voice no longer carried its old certainty.

— This was never about the chip, — I said. — I tried to explain that from the very beginning.

— I believe you now, — he said quietly. — The problem is, you can be arrested. But what's happening out there, — he nodded toward the window, toward the city, the country, the whole horizon, — that can't be.

He looked at me the way you look at a person standing on the threshold of an event larger than himself — and for the first time in all the time we'd known each other, I saw in his eyes not suspicion, not alarm, but something like a bewildered, involuntary relief.

That night I didn't sleep — but, like Kira a few weeks before, not from insomnia. I lay there feeling something begin to sound, right at the very edge of perception, that I had spent so long trying to explain to others in words — not a thought, not an image, but a whole, wordless knowing: the crisis that had seemed to us like the end of the story was, in fact, its middle. The real event — the one all of this had been set in motion for, long before we were even born — was only just beginning, and no law, no sealed door, could decide whether it would happen or not. Only one question remained, far simpler and far more frightening: what would each of us, individually, do now that the threshold had already been crossed.



Chapter 10. Culmination

The hearing was scheduled in the largest hall they could find — not because anyone was expecting a spectacle, but because no ordinary office could hold everyone who wanted to be there. I was summoned as the company's founder, formally to give testimony in the case concerning violation of the law "On the Circulation of Technologies for Direct Access to Consciousness." In fact, it was no longer a case about a law. It was the one remaining public place where the state could still pretend it had a grip on what was happening.

I sat at the table alone — Alisa and Max had insisted on that, saying someone needed to stay behind and deal with what was happening outside — and looked out at a hall full of people, each of them, it seemed, afraid in their own way of what was about to happen.

Presiding was the minister who oversaw the "Honest Society" program — the one whose name was on the law. Beside him sat lawyers, experts, representatives of the very plainclothes agency that a month earlier had forced the bracelet onto a detainee's wrist. In the front row, apart from the others, sat the man from the "Barrier." He didn't look at me with hostility. He barely looked at me at all, as if he already knew how it would end and didn't want to give it away ahead of time.

— Tell us, — the minister began, — in plain words: what have you created, and why can't it be controlled the way any other technology is controlled?

Once, I would have started with the chip, with the biofield, with resonance — with the technical side, easier for a mind accustomed to dividing the world into devices and protocols to accept. This time I didn't.

— I haven't created anything, — I said. — I found a door that was always there, and made the first step up to it a little lower, so it would be easier to climb onto. That's the full extent of what I'm capable of affecting. Beyond that, a person walks on their own — on their own legs, by their own intention — and neither I nor you can walk in their place.

— That's philosophy, — one of the lawyers said, irritated. — We need facts. Is this technology dangerous to state security?

— A technology can't be dangerous to something built on truth, — I said, — exactly the way light can't be dangerous to something built on a solid foundation. The danger isn't in the door. It's in what stands on the other side of it in each of us — and that has nothing to do with the chip, or with the law you passed.

The hall went quiet — not the silence of confusion, but of recognition. I saw the man from the "Barrier" go still. I saw the minister go still. And then something happened that hadn't been in any script written in advance for this hearing.

The plainclothes man from the "Honest Society" agency — the very one who, a month earlier, had held a signed consent form and demanded an immediate session — suddenly rose from his seat. He didn't say anything loud. He simply stood there, as if he'd forgotten why he'd gotten up, and on his face was the same expression I'd seen on hundreds of people over the past year — the expression of a man in whom something had shifted, silently and irreversibly.

— I haven't slept in three nights, — he finally said, addressing no one in particular. — Not because I was working. Because I couldn't. Something in me won't let me... — he stopped, searching for a word that hadn't been in his vocabulary before, — won't let me say what I don't think anymore, or think what I don't believe. I came here with a prepared speech about the risks. I can't deliver it. It's a lie, and I feel that as clearly as I feel my own hand.

No one in the hall laughed or interrupted him. Even the minister stayed silent, looking at his own subordinate as if seeing him for the first time.

— Is this the thing you've been talking about? — the minister asked me quietly, after a long pause.

— This is exactly it, — I answered. — Not an epidemic, and not a conspiracy. It's simply that at some point a threshold gets crossed — not by one person, but by many at once — and after that it stops mattering who's holding the law in their hands. The law can decide what to do about the chip. It can't decide what to do about this.

Professor Gromov, invited as an independent expert, asked to speak only once it became clear that the hall itself, with no help from him, had arrived at the edge of the very thought he'd been leading me toward all year.

— You weren't fighting a company, — he said, addressing everyone at once. — You were fighting a sunrise, mistaking it for a fire. A sunrise can't be canceled by decree. It can only be met — on time or too late, calmly or in a panic. The question in front of you now isn't "forbid or permit." The question is whether you'll manage to restructure what you govern faster than it restructures itself without you.

The session didn't end in a decision that same day — such things aren't settled by an hour-long vote. But something broke in the very logic of what was happening, and I felt it before I heard the official words: the law that a week ago had seemed unshakable was starting to lose

meaning right before the eyes of those who had passed it, because enforcing it now would mean confiscating not chips, but a person's very capacity to be honest — and no state in history had a precedent for that.

After the session, the man from the "Barrier" came up to me — for the first time in a month, with a direct, open look.

— We offered you protection against the chip being stolen, back when we thought this was about a secret, — he said. — Then we tried to stop it, once we understood there was no secret. Now, it seems, we're going to have to figure out what to protect — if that's even still the right word for what's happening.

— Maybe the word is different now, — I said. — Not controller. Not guard. Maybe just — someone who was standing close enough, for long enough, to be among the first to notice the sunrise.

He didn't answer, but for a second I thought I saw on his face the same recognition that a few minutes earlier had moved the plainclothes man from "Honest Society" — only deeper and quieter, as if it had been waiting its turn for a long time.

That evening, Alisa, Max, and I stood on the roof of our building — the one place where the sealed laboratory door no longer mattered, because what we had built had long since stopped fitting within four walls. The city below burned with its ordinary lights, looking no different from the city it had been a year ago. And yet I knew — not thought, but knew, wholly, without a single word — that somewhere out there, behind thousands of windows, the very thing Gromov had spoken of was happening: not a revolt, not an epidemic, not a technology — but something so simple and so immense that no name had been invented for it yet, because it was happening for the first time not to one person, but to everyone at once.

— What now? — Alisa asked, not taking her eyes off the city.

I didn't answer right away — not because I didn't know, but because the answer, for the first time in a long while, didn't need words. It was here, all around us, spilled across the city in the light of thousands of windows, each one burning just slightly differently than before — not brighter, not dimmer, just more honestly.

— Now, — I finally said, — we find out what the world turns into when it no longer has anything left to hide.



Chapter 11. A New Reality

The law was repealed six months later — quietly, with no announcements or ceremonial sessions, a single line in a list of statutes no longer in force. By that point there was almost nothing left to repeal: there was no one left to register, nothing left to confiscate, and "Honest Society," conceived as an instrument of coercion, had quietly transformed into what it probably should have been from the very start — simply a name for something that was happening on its own, with no program behind it at all.

I often think back to that evening on the roof, and Alisa's question, for which I'd had no words at the time except one: now. Looking back, I understand that "now" stretched out over years, and each of those years added detail to the picture we'd only seen in broad strokes back then, in the light of a thousand windows.

The first thing to change was "the Telepath" itself — or rather, the need for it. We didn't close the company, but its whole purpose turned upside down: where before we'd taught people to enter the state with the gadget's help, now most people came to us already knowing how, just to check themselves, to be sure, to get a name for something that was already living inside them. The chip turned from a key into a reference guide, into the first step that many people climbed past without even noticing it had been there.

— Remember the water wings? — Alisa said to me once, looking at a warehouse of finished bracelets whose demand kept dropping month after month. — I think children are soon going to stop needing them at all.

She turned out to be right sooner than we thought. Those born into a world where honesty had already become cheaper than lying, and the state of no-thought was as ordinary a skill as counting or reading, knew no threshold but their own growing up. They didn't fight the field, didn't try to hack it, didn't look for advantage in it — because they'd grown up hearing from their parents not about a miracle, but about a fact, as natural as electricity in an outlet. What had seemed like a revelation to my generation seemed to theirs simply the way the world worked — the very thing the teacher at the conference had once spoken of: not a superpower, but literacy.

Kira had long since severed her last tie to the bracelet and now worked with such children — teaching them not technique, but patience, because the only thing worth teaching in the new world turned out to be the skill of not getting in your own way. Roman opened his own small practice in another city; I learned of his successes from occasional letters, always short, always honest down to the last line — in this world, letters had grown shorter, because the need to talk one's way around the truth had disappeared.

The man from the "Barrier" — I never did call him anything else, though I'd known his name for a long time — stayed close to us, but his role changed beyond recognition. He no longer guarded secrets or hunted for vulnerabilities. He became what anyone standing beside something bigger than themselves probably should have been from the very beginning — a witness, helping those just beginning to open up not to lose their footing on the threshold.

— You know what's funny, — he said to me once, — my whole life I searched for something to protect. Now I just help people not be afraid of what's already happened. It turned out to be a far more honest job.

Professor Gromov didn't live to see the day the world finally stopped arguing about whether what we were doing was real — he died quietly, in the spring, in his apartment, with the window open, through which, his daughter told me afterward, ordinary morning light was pouring into the room. I didn't cry at his funeral — not because I felt no grief, but because for the first time in my life, grief wasn't accompanied by any sense of loss. Something in his words had long since become part of me, which meant part of him kept sounding on inside me, the way a resonance sounds on in a body once it has begun, no longer needing its source in order to continue.

Logos — the Mirror, as we called it — had long since stopped being necessary for me personally: what once took effort had become an ordinary state I spent most of my day in, with no strain, with no risk of a thought shattering the hologram into pieces. But we didn't shut the program down. It stayed — for the new people, just beginning their path to the door, for those who still had to learn to hold the state before it became as habitual as breathing.

Sometimes I think about the cell the professor once used to open our very first serious conversation — about how every cell of the body carries the whole pattern of the whole, folded up like a seed waiting not for a command, but simply for the conditions to unfold. We didn't invent the conditions. We simply stopped getting in their way — first in ourselves, then in each other, and then, it seems, in everything our narrow, uncertain, but real light could reach.

Tonight, as I write these lines, the city outside my window is burning again — the same city, and already an entirely different one. Not brighter than before. Just more honest, as I once told Alisa — a light that no longer pretends to come from something else, but simply recognizes itself in everyone who looks at it without looking away.

The resonance continues. It needs no wire, no chip, no law, not even this book — but if it helps even one person hear that same quiet whisper of the field in themselves a little sooner than I heard it, then it, too, has made its own step a little lower.

Everything came out of light. And it seems everything returns to light too — not at the end of the road, but in every real step of it.